disappear? What is a good approach here? Let's explore the architecture of any kind of platform to understand how we can come up with a quite modular answer to this problem.

7.3.1 Platform architecture explained

Carliss Baldwin and C. Jason Woodard, in "The Architecture of Platforms: A Unified View" (http://mng.bz/XaWp), shine a different light on platforms that we'll explore in this section. Platforms are not easy to define, as you can see in this chapter, and ambiguity may exist even in the terms defining a platform.

But the architecture of any kind of platform is surprisingly constant. We can find the same kind of architectural components inside developer platforms, self-serve data platforms, a brick-and-mortar marketplace, or even Stripe.

Take your central town square as an example. In many small towns, it hosts a farmers market, usually at a fixed time. The selling farmers change from time to time, but they know where they have to sign up. The buyers change all the time, but everyone knows the place and time. Additionally, a central town square usually supplies the needed electricity and water taps for farmers to use.

A central town square thus becomes a platform with three components:

- The buyers and the farmers are the *complements*, or participants, of the platform.
- The town square (place) and the fixed time together become the *platform interface*, everything required for buyers and farmers to interact much more easily.
- Everything on the town square and everything around it, possibly the processes around it such as charges for renting a space at the market, make up the *platform kernel*. This component includes everything that provides value, such as water taps and electricity for the farmers or nice decorations for the visitors.